Kanth that if he took one step towards Nalini, he would kill him. And Murugan looked like he indeed would. The security guards encircled Murugan in seconds, with their guns aimed at him.

After a moment of tense silence, Nalini resumed the confession.

The sound of the explosion was deafening, she said. Shubha and Nalini ran out of the women's enclosure and reached the statue of Indira Gandhi that Rajiv had garlanded just about twenty minutes ago. Sivarasan was waiting for them there. Sivarasan confirmed that Rajiv Gandhi was dead, Dhanu was martyred and so was Haribabu. They had to leave the place right away. Nalini was panting. Sivarasan and Shubha, trained in coping with such situations, dragged Nalini away from the scene. A little ahead, Sivarasan knocked on the door of a house and asked for some water for Nalini to drink before they could escape in an autorickshaw.

They changed the autorickshaw at Poonamallee and continued their journey until Jayakumar's house in Kodungaiyur. Sivarasan immediately called Subha Sundaram and informed him that Haribabu had died in the blast as he had got too close to Dhanu. Along with Haribabu, the camera was lost too. It had to be retrieved, Sivarasan told Sundaram. At any cost.

After overcoming the initial shock, Sundaram called a fellow photographer, Ramamurthy, and asked if he was still at Sriperumbudur and if he could collect the camera. Ramamurthy said he hadn't gone to Sriperumbudur.

On 24 May, when *The Hindu* published the picture of Dhanu wearing an orange-and-green salwar kameez and holding a sandalwood garland at Sriperumbudur, in the company of Sivarasan, news of the picture spread like wildfire. From Jaffna, Pottu Amman sent a wireless message query to Sivarasan about whether Dhanu could be identified in the photo. But that very day, Murugan, Nalini, her mother Padma, Shubha and Sivarasan left for Tirupathi to offer thanks to Lord Venkateshwara and returned to Madras the next day. On the trip, Murugan reportedly asked Sivarasan why Dhanu and Shubha were chosen and not him. Apparently, Murugan had expressed his willingness to act as the human bomb. Sivarasan was aware of that, besides Pottu Amman and Prabhakaran. Sivarasan revealed it was